

God is Breath Training Program - Course 1

Breath, Concentration, and the God Ideal

Lesson 4 Practices and Assignments

(by Murshid Wali Ali, with some updates by Sheikh Muiz)

Beloved Ones of God,

Peace and Blessings of the Holy Spirit be with you as we continue on the path together. I am thankful that we have formed a caravan to support each other in the ongoing realization of the wonders to be found in and through the Breath.

Below are the basic practices that have been assigned for Lesson 4. There are a few changes from what we have been doing so far. A fourth stage has been added to our basic breathing meditation practice; it involves connecting in the depth of your feeling with one of the Illuminated Souls. Please review this. The other addition, to the Descent of the Dove is in the description of the visualization while doing practice inhaling Hu through the crown and exhaling Allah through the heart.

Our purpose is to maintain our daily rhythm of concentration and to keep cultivating our deep interest and connection with all the practice and teachings. Please not rush through the texts we are studying, rather take the time to savor them and reflect on them.

May we be graced to keep remembering our focus and to feel the beauty at the heart of our process.

Love and Blessings,
Wali Ali, 2013

Some specific daily practices to take on for Lesson 4:

1) Sufi Invocation – 3 times

Begin with recitation of the Sufi Invocation three times, followed by inner reflection in which you connect with the meaning of this prayer. Then clearly find and establish your own intention and your own authentic prayer ... for this practice session, for your life, for whatever may arise.

2) Ya Raqib – 33 times vocally, then several times on the breath (Fikr), then a few more breaths just feeling the essence of it without the mental recitation (Fikr as-Sirr)

Remember to consciously and gently call forth heart-centered attention and interest in what you are focused upon in your awareness.

3) Daily Sitting Meditation – 15 minutes

Stage 1: Allow yourself to breathe naturally. Notice the rhythm of this breath and consciously maintain this rhythm. Gradually allow the breath to become longer and more refined. Become aware of the small natural pause at the top and bottom of the breath.

Stage 2: Place your attention on the magnetism (prana) that is carried by the breath. You are drawing from the All-Pervading Life in Space. Center your awareness in the heart (middle of the chest) and consciously bring the magnetism into the heart as you inhale and radiate it as you exhale. Your whole physical body becomes charged with life-force. Feel this as a palpable energetic presence that continually fills your atmosphere with livingness.

Stage 3: Retaining your focus in the heart, recognize this magnetism as love and consciously call it forth. Using the rhythm that has been established in your breath, stay attentive to this regular swing — long, refined, rhythmical, and begin to seek loving connection with the beauty of the Divine Perfection, as you imagine it.

Stage 4: As you do this, feel your heart connecting and merging with one of the Illuminated Souls, such that you naturally begin to experience life through those eyes, ears, thoughts, etc.

Always stay alert, and if your breath begins to stray from this balanced and refined state, gently bring it back. Begin to slowly intone the sound “Allah, Allah” in thought and feeling matching the rhythm of the breath.

Let remembrance of the perfect One naturally fill the length and breadth of the breath. Constantly flow with the awareness of the joy of the essence of your life in Allah, and be alive to love's longing for completion in that Oneness.

4) Descent of the Dove Concentration and Irfan – 5 minutes, on ALTERNATE DAYS

This practice is to be done on alternate days with reciting Surah Ikhlas and the concentration on Ya 'Ahad, Ya Samad described in #5.

Concentrate for five minutes on the Dove as the descent of the Spirit of Guidance, the Divine Breath, as described here and in the reading selection for Lesson 3 – *Murshid SAM's Commentary on Gatha Series 1, Naqshibandi (Symbology) Number 5: The Symbol of the Dove*, PDF page 3, top.

Inhale hearing the sound "Huuuuu" and receiving the breath through the crown center while at the same time visualizing the descent of the dove, the Holy Spirit, the Spirit of Guidance. Allow this to flow into the heart.

At the top of the inhalation, pause briefly to accept the guidance it brings and visualize the Name Allah written in light in or on your heart. You can trace the letters, one by one, in visualization, and with a finger if it helps, or you can visualize the whole Name on the heart. This is the practice called *Irfan*.

Then exhale "Allah" through the heart — send forth the expression of the Divine as a beacon of powerful compassionate vibration that is sealed with the imprimatur of the Name Allah shining forth in it. Authentically offer the stream of living magnetism, generous well-being, and beneficial intention through the heart.

5) Recitation of Surah Ikhlas – 1 time, followed by a Breath Contemplation using Ya 'Ahad Ya Samad – 5 minutes, ON ALTERNATE DAYS

This practice is to be done on alternate days with the Descent of the Dove Concentration described in #4
Follow the recitation of Surah Ikhlas with the breathing contemplation practice using Ya 'Ahad and Ya Samad.

Surah al-Ikhlâs – The Sincerity

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim

(We begin) in the Name of Allah, Everlasting Mercy, Infinite Compassion.

Qul huwa Allahu 'Ahad

Say, Hu is Allah, The One

Allahu us-Samad

Allah, The Eternal, Absolute

Lam yalid, wa lam yulad

Hu never gave birth, and Hu never was born

wa lam yaku llahu kufuwan 'Ahad

And there is none comparable to The One.

When you exhale, mentally and in feeling repeat "Ya Samad", continually dissolving into the Oneness that is unending. Breathing out "Ya Samad" is the same as breathing out "Toward the One" and "becoming melting snow", dissolving the sense of your small self into the eternal, continuous and unending, All-Pervading Oneness.

When you inhale, mentally and in feeling repeat "Ya 'Ahad.". There is nothing outside of the Unity of the One that is al-'Ahad. Experience this Unity as a dot, and with the inhalation of Ya 'Ahad draw the reality of All That Is into a dot and experience integration of self in this dot. You become aware of the One that is the ultimate Unity of Being. Nothing is outside of this One. Nothing can be added to it or subtracted from it.

To be fully conscious as you perform this practice asks you to accept that what you call your own awareness is actually an activity of the Only Being, and is nothing but that Being.

This practice is highly recommended because oscillating back and forth between the dot and the continuation of the infinite and eternal circumference of the expanding circle gives the right psychological framework for progress in meditation. It allows us to ease into the letting go of self, of "dying before death".

The Sufi Invocation uses all these levels of meaning of the One.

6) Qasab (Alternate Nostril) Breathing Practice – 5 cycles

(If you need to refer to the detailed description, explanation, and steps for Qasab, please refer to the "Lesson Practices & Assignments PDF".)

Please remember that each breath is deep, full, smooth, and even, for both exhalations and inhalations, but without being heavy or coarse or strained — and notice that the breathing for this practice is different than the gentle, refined, and delicate breathing we're using in our daily, Toward the One, Watching the Breath Meditations.

The nostril not being breathed through is gently held closed with a thumb or finger, and both are gently held closed during the retentions.

The pattern for the timing of the exhalations, inhalations, and retentions, in the way we'll be doing Qasab, is 8 syllables for both exhalations and inhalations, and 16 syllables for the retentions. The pattern is like this: 8 – 8 – 16; repeating mentally and in feeling "Allah Shafee Allah Kafee" during exhalations, inhalations, and the retentions. The retentions are twice as long as either the exhalations or the inhalations, unless your mentor or Guide has suggested that you make changes to this pattern.

Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee – 8 syllables for the exhalations,
and
Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee – 8 for the inhalations,
and
Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee, Al-lah Sha-fee, Al-lah Ka-fee – 16 syllables for the retentions.

To begin:

Close the left nostril, and exhale through the right for 8 syllables
Immediately close the right and open the left, and inhale through the left for 8 syllables
Close both nostrils and hold for 16 syllables
Open the left and exhale through the left for 8 syllables
Immediately close the left and open the right, and inhale through the right for 8 syllables
Close both nostrils and hold for 16

This is 1 cycle, and we'll do 5 cycles daily.

To finish:

At the conclusion of the practice, take a few minutes to be fully aware of your breath in both nostrils. Throughout the practice we are connecting in our breath and in our prayer with God's all sufficient power of healing and purification.

Stay still for a bit, and in the manner of ar-Raqib, notice with gentle, loving interest and curiosity, how you feel, what your body, your breath, your energy field, your heart is feeling like.

Very importantly: There must be no straining, no tension, no "bearing down", while holding the inhalation, and no "toughing it out" waiting to exhale. The moment you begin to feel like you need to exhale you should exhale.

And if you're having any difficulty or challenge at all, with the increased energy, with becoming spaced out, or with what may be arising from the depths of your psyche, either during the practice, or at other points during the day please report this to your mentor and your Guide (if you have one) right away, so they can assist you.

TIP: If you haven't reached the end of the 16 syllables during the retention and you're feeling like you have to exhale, you've been mentally reciting the syllables too slowly for your retention capacity at this point. Try again, reciting a bit more quickly overall, rather than stopping short of the full 16 syllables for the retention, or reciting just the 16 syllables more quickly.

The tempo through all 3 stages should remain steady and even, no matter how slowly or quickly you recite the syllables — 8, 8, 16.

7) 20 Purification Breaths and Healing Prayer

There are many different forms in which this practice is done. In this class we are placing our attention throughout the breaths, on the 3 avenues of purification mentioned in the prayer Nayaz.

Finish the Healing Breaths with Nayaz, the Healing Prayer, again opening to the 3 powers.

The Purification Breaths:

Each breath is slow, gentle, and refined, inhalations and exhalations the same length. Each of the breathing patterns is repeated 5 times, mentally and in feeling repeating "Ya Shafee" (O Healer) during the inhalations, and "Ya Kafee" (O Remedy, Sufficient for every need) during the exhalations.

1st pattern: IN the NOSE, and OUT the NOSE.

2nd pattern: IN the NOSE, and OUT the MOUTH.

3rd pattern: IN in the MOUTH, and OUT the NOSE.

4th pattern: IN the MOUTH, and OUT the MOUTH.

The Healing Prayer, Nayaz:

"Beloved Lord, almighty God, through the rays of the Sun, through the waves of the air, through Thy All-Pervading Life in Space, purify and revivify me, and I pray, heal my body, heart, and soul."

8) Shiva's 112 Centering Breath Meditations – Choose 1 of these every day, do it for 5 minutes

(These 112 meditations are excerpted from the Vijnana Bhairava, Sochanda, and Malini Vijaya Tantras, and were included by Paul Reps at the end of his book "Zen Flesh, Zen Bones". A much more poetic, body-centered and sensuous, and tantric English rendering of these 112, and more, from the Vijnana Bhairava Tantra are available as "The Radiance Sutras", section 2. The Yukti Verses, by Lorin Roche.

A comparison of these 2 renderings of the same Sanskrit verses is included after the assignments.)

#3. Whenever inbreath and outbreath fuse, at this instant touch the energy-less, energy-filled CENTER.

#23. Feel your substance, bones, flesh, blood, saturated with Cosmic Essence.

#4. When breath is all out (up) and stopped of itself, or all in (down) and stopped — in such universal pause, one's small self vanishes.

#31. With intangible breath in center of forehead, as this reaches heart at the moment of sleep, have direction over dreams and over death itself.

#56. ... As breath comes silently in, feel the sound H-H-H-H.

To be done at any time:

9) Toward the One Walking Practice – at least once a week

Do the following walking practice in nature if possible when you can.

Breathing “Toward the One” in and out from the heart center. Opening, encouraging, and allowing your heart to feel lovingly drawn by the beauty of the Perfect One, and feeling the inner harmony of your connection with the Source and Goal of all, you radiate the light-ray of your intention along the path of your life.

At the same time, feel your heart drawn to the Source by its magnetism, beauty, and perfection. Be aware of both poles of this practice simultaneously — your heart and the Source, calling to each other, drawing each other together.

10) Attention to Breath – Periodically throughout the day

Check in with your breath throughout the day and notice its condition. For example, it could be Jelal, Jemal, Kemal, Urooj, Zaval, refined/coarse, powerful/dull, broad/narrow, etc.

After checking in, consciously confirm the rhythm in your breath or, when needed, establish a rhythm in your breath. Stay with this awareness of the swing of your breath and allow it to gradually become longer and more refined.

Then continue with your activities. Notice any way in which your emotions have been influenced by having done the practice mentioned above.

11) Journaling – At least once a week

Continue to write in your journal at least once a week or more. In addition to noting the condition of your breath at different times, and what you learned from it, also give some attention in your journal to the different things that your breath connects with and what it draws from that connection.